State Review LEARNINGS:

John brown University

TRADITIONAL Route

On-Site Review: April 22-23, 2025

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, “Candidate Recruitment and Completion,” is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, “Supporting Workforce Needs,” are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

JOHN BROWN UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL ROUTE

Overall Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
MEETS	MEETS	APPROACHING

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	APPROACHING	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
Recruiting additional candidates to increase enrollment in subject shortage areas will support the program's Standard 1 performance moving forward. *(Focus Areas: Criteria 1.2b)*		

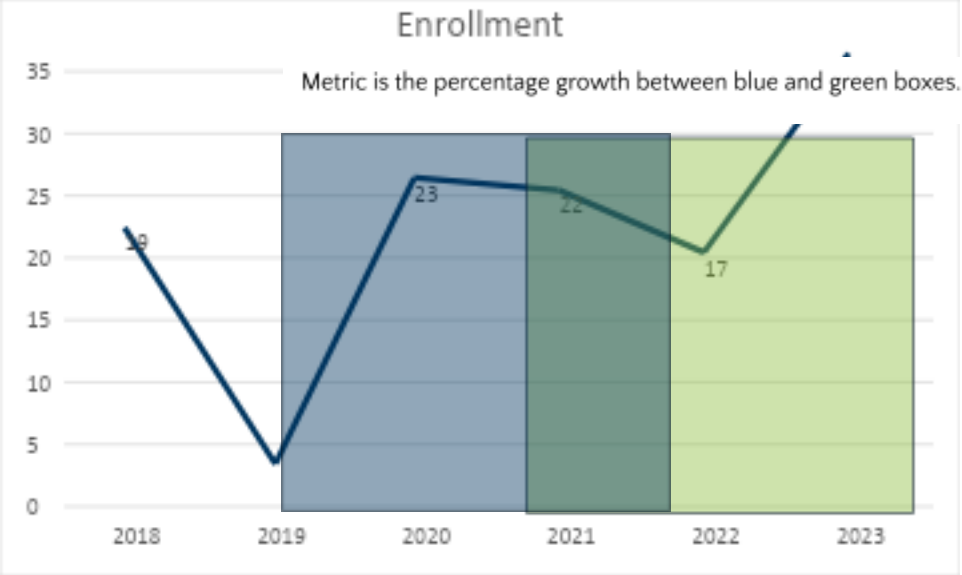
INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (I.e., Standards 1–3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	John Brown's assessment of their traditional program meets all necessary indicators.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs

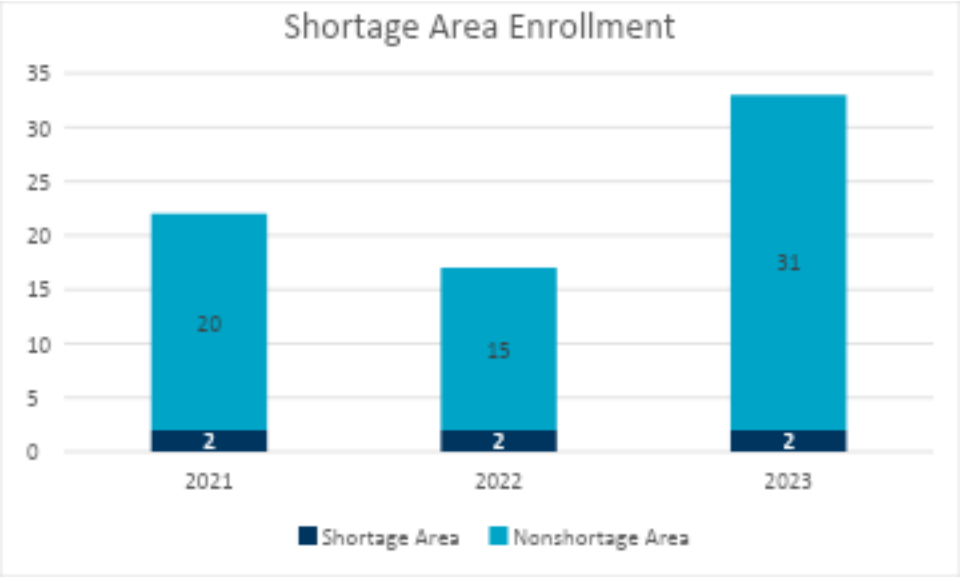
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	71.4%	EXCEEDS



*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a "Meets" rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an "Exceeds" rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need

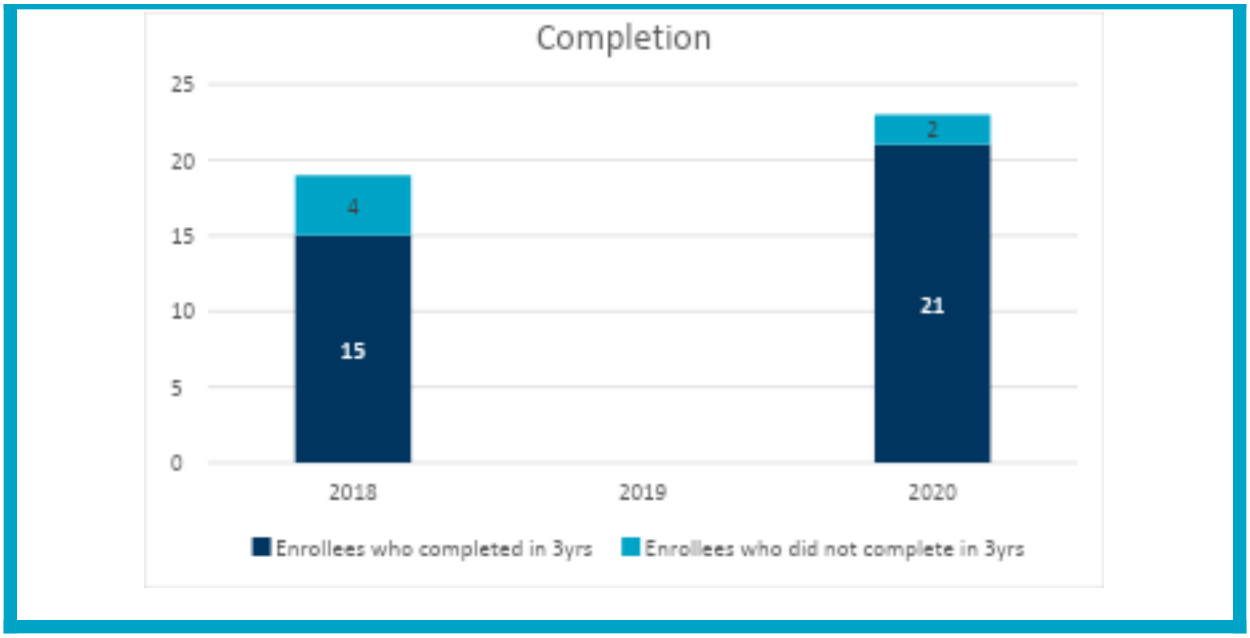
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	8%	BELOW



*Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline), demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased), and state focus areas. Current licensure areas of shortage: Biology (7-12), Chemistry (7-12), Physics (7-12), Foreign Language (K-12), Math (7-12), Math (4-8), Science (4-8), Special Education (K-12)

INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	86%	EXCEEDS


Completion
25
20
15
10
5
0
4
15
2
21
2018
2019
2020
Enrollees who completed in 3yrs
Enrollees who did not complete in 3yrs

Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	**Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences**	**Indicator 2.3 Development**
MEETS	APPROACHING	MEETS

Recommendations

John Brown University provided evidence to highlight its commitment to developing candidates to prepare them with the knowledge, systems and structures they need to teach in Arkansas schools by aligning coursework with clinical experiences and providing a variety of field experiences. Candidates have clear goals and milestones to help them successfully complete the program, and it was evident to reviewers that teacher candidates are supported and successful.

Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include:

- Audit coursework for classroom connections and reflect with course instructors on alignment between Educator Competencies, Arkansas Teaching Standards and coursework. *(Focus Area: Criteria 2.1b Metric 2)*
- By 2026-2027, EPPs will need to provide evidence that experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents have received DESE-recognized coaching training. JBU should ensure that its training program meets this bar, and that clinical supervisors as well as experienced mentor teachers receive ongoing professional development. *(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.2b Metrics 1 and 3)*
- Strengthen partnership with schools/districts so that there are clear communication, collaboration, and feedback loops. *(Focus Area: Criteria 2.2c Metric 1)*
- Consider revising the structure of coaching conversations to include a discussion of student work and incorporate assignments that require candidates to analyze and reflect on the data. (*Focus Area: Criteria 2.3b Metric 2)*

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
MEETS

Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction
MEETS

Coursework clearly incorporates nationally recognized best practices around content instruction, including recognizing and using high-quality instructional materials and evidence-based practices. Reviewers saw multiple courses that include cooperative learning and reciprocal teaching strategies as foundational approaches (e.g., Reading Comprehension for Elementary Teachers (ED3323), Teaching Elementary Reading and Language Arts: The Science of Reading (ED3333), Teaching Elementary Math (ED4383), and multiple courses that incorporate professional learning communities (PLCs) as core structures of the coursework (e.g., Frameworks for Teaching 1:Elementary Education (ED3123), Education Capstone (ED4912)). Several courses reference HQIM standards but do not indicate how those

standards are incorporated (e.g., Teaching Elementary Math (ED4383)); however, ED4912 requires candidates to complete a project on the HQIM used in their placement classrooms. ED4912 also incorporates RTI at Work and Google-certified technology integration. Several courses in the elementary education pathway demonstrate Science of Reading proficiency, and Disciplinary Literacy (ED3153) demonstrates Science of Reading awareness in the secondary education pathway through AR Ideas. Mathematical Structures (MTH2143) incorporates Cognitively Guided Instruction (CGI), including having candidates reflect on the use of CGI in the classrooms they observe.

In the Coursework focus group, participants expressed they were tasked to evaluate and incorporate materials that align with state standards and curriculum goals, such as the Arkansas K-12 standards in lesson planning. One key practice emphasized was the student's use of resources like the Library of Congress and the Encyclopedia of Arkansas, which provide authentic and high-quality content that is both accessible and engaging for students. One participant said, "we examined lesson plans from various curricula, comparing different instructional strategies such as grouping methods and assessments."

In the Course Instructor focus group, participants shared examples of how HQIM is incorporated saying, "HQIM are intentionally incorporated into our course lectures and assignments to ensure alignment with state standards and support preservice teachers in developing strong instructional practices. For example, in courses focused on disciplinary literacy and the Science of Reading (SoR), we integrate specific assignments aligned with HQIM, asking students to analyze and compare curriculum used in their classroom placements with these standards." In the elementary education track, they have also partnered with the campus library and local school districts to align their course content with the HQIM they are using, allowing students to better understand and apply these materials in real-world contexts. Additionally, the program director meets monthly with district superintendents and curriculum leaders in a cooperative focused on HQIM alignment and has completed four targeted training courses on HQIM implementation. These experiences have informed updates to course design, making the incorporation of HQIM more intentional.

In the course, Elementary Math (ED4383), reviewers noted additional examples of best practices. Candidates spent time looking at the Standards of Mathematical Practice. These are embedded in math standards for the state and candidates spend time defining these practices and articulating about how they discuss these standards with students and parents. The instructor noted that materials shared with students came from MathQuest. Although no evidence of HQIM was noted in this lesson, the Standards of Mathematical Practice (SMP) are aligned to Arkansas K-12 math standards and are incorporated into math HQIM.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development

MEETS

Coursework clearly and intentionally familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K-12 Standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area. Candidates utilize the AR K-12 Academic Standards to complete three formal lesson plans in their elementary literacy courses (ED3323) and ED3333). Similarly, the elementary math courses (MTH2143, MTH2183, and ED4383) require candidates to compile resources aligned to each K-12 standard and to plan/teach lessons based on the K-12 standards.

One participant in the Coursework focus group said, "Arkansas standards have been a focus since freshman year, we've gotten so familiar with them because we tie everything to a standard and try to connect standards across disciplines." The students have opportunities to explore vertical alignment by examining how standards evolve across grade levels, ensuring understanding of developmental progressions and how to design age-appropriate lessons. One participant said, "In the differentiated learning course, we modify product process and content. That class helps us to look at standards to make a learning goal that can be adapted in various ways, and the emphasis is on all students meeting the goal even though some students may need more scaffolding or need different prompting."

Participants in the Course Instructor focus group shared that over the past few years, the incorporation and utilization of the Arkansas K-12 Standards have shown significant improvement, reflecting intentional efforts to align assignments, objectives, and instructional planning with state expectations. One key development has been the consistent practice of requiring candidates to match standards to assignments, helping them internalize how standards drive classroom instruction.

In some coursework observations, reviewers also saw evidence of standards. In the observed Secondary Pedagogy course, candidates worked with a partner to choose an AR K-12 standard for their content area, develop a pre-test that can be used to assess students' prior knowledge, create and deliver a 30-minute remediation lesson, and assess students' progress on the post-test.

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher
APPROACHING

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses
MEETS

Courses are clearly and intentionally sequenced across programs. Courses are numbered and required as a specific path of study for each licensure area, including both pre- and corequisites. New course progressions across all areas emphasize general education first, then focus on the frameworks for great teaching, before moving into best practices for each content area and finishing with implementation of content-specific pedagogy in the classroom when candidates are in the residency.

Candidates in the Coursework Focus group agreed their courses are sequenced in a way to support their growth as a teacher. One candidate described the progression saying, "we are on a four-year plan. In our freshman and sophomore years, courses are content heavy and included core curriculum. In our junior and senior year, coursework is more focused on pedagogy and how to take what I've learned to teach someone else."

Course instructors affirmed this by noting that early courses lay the foundation with core pedagogical knowledge and basic teaching strategies, while later courses introduce more complex concepts and practices, such as integrating disciplinary literacy into content areas like science and social studies. For example, candidates might begin by learning foundational reading strategies in an early literacy course and then apply these skills to teach science or social studies, using evidence-based curricula in more specialized settings.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework
APPROACHING

Coursework somewhat incorporates Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards. Every course syllabus reviewed included references to TESS, and most also included references to inTASC. Several courses (ED3123, MTH2143, and MTH2183) included substantive activities to support candidates in becoming more familiar with the TESS rubric, including explicit reflections on each TESS component during observations. Only two courses (ED3323, ED3333) included explicit references to the Arkansas Educator Competencies, but there was no evidence that candidates are actually supported in making sense of them through the coursework. For example, in ED3123, while the course focuses on unpacking standards, Professional Learning Communities (PLCs), and aligning with TESS and inTASC, there is currently no direct integration of K-12 standards or AEC/ATS in practice lessons.

Course Instructors shared that the program has a matrix that maps the Arkansas Teaching Standards and Educator Competencies to assignments and course content that helps track students' progress and ensure their learning aligns with state expectations. These are also included in course syllabi. Instructors also noted that as the program transitions to a year-long internship, revisiting syllabi and course sequencing is necessary to ensure that foundational courses are taught early, while more complex skills are introduced later, allowing for a seamless integration of theory and practice.

Reviewers noted evidence of standards in all three course observations and saw evidence of the competencies in one observation. Reviewers noted that the instructor focused on the mathematical teaching practices (MTP), which are aligned to the NCTM competencies. The Arkansas K-12 standards are aligned with this as well. The course content observed was able to incorporate both the MTP and the Arkansas K-12 standards.

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience
MEETS

Coursework is clearly aligned to clinical experience. Courses are structured so that candidates are consistently observing classrooms throughout their methods classes. This includes elementary literacy courses (ED3323, ED3333) that scaffold responsibility by having candidates teach literacy topics to their peers before creating formal lesson plans for use with students. Additionally, math courses (ED4383) scaffold learning by having candidates complete in-depth lesson planning projects before being expected to plan and teach two full lessons on their own. Candidates have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment with their clinical supervisor and course instructors. Several elementary math courses (MTH2143, MTH2183) require candidates to complete graded reflections after each classroom observation that focus on TESS and content-specific best practices. Terminal courses like School Experience (ED49110) require that candidates reflect on their internship evaluation and the totality of their experiences to create a professional growth plan (PGP), conduct 30 hours of clinical experiences aligned with their PGP goals, and

deliver a final presentation assessing their progress. The other terminal course, Education Capstone (ED4912), provides candidates with opportunities to hear from educational professionals about the most pressing topics in education and reflect on how they have seen those topics play out in their clinical experiences.

All participants in the Coursework focus group agreed they have opportunities to reflect on how their coursework and field experiences align. One participant shared that every field experience requires a reflection, saying "right now we are doing 30 hours of field experience across the semester, and we have a reflection assignment required after every three hours. The reflection might be specific to how you saw certain strategies used, or could be more general processing about what we felt worked well or not well"

Reviewers saw evidence of alignment in two course observations. For example, in the Education Capstone course, several students drew connections from their reading and discussion to their experiences in school placements (including the importance of vulnerability and positive thinking during PLCs), as well as connections to previous readings and discussions in other pedagogy courses. The candidate who discussed professional learning communities referenced how their participation in PLCs--where educators share ideas and strategies--helped them connect theoretical knowledge from their coursework with instances from the PLCs they participated in during internship.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors show deep knowledge of Arkansas K12 standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy. Data was only provided for seven of the 10 course instructors listed. Of the seven, three hold doctorates and three hold master's degrees. Information on licensure areas was only provided for two instructors, so it is unclear how many have former teaching experience. None of the instructors have completed the state HQIM, and only four have been trained on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. However, the EPP has provided some internal HQIM training to provide space for instructors to reflect on opportunities for modeling HQIM and supporting candidates with HQIM internalization. Additional certifications and training include Trauma-Informed Care, Arkansas Leadership Academy, TESS Credentialed Evaluator, Cognitive Coaching, and various literacy and math instructional programs. These credentials and ongoing professional development ensure that instructors are well-prepared with both deep content knowledge and effective teaching strategies aligned with Arkansas K-12 standards.

During the coursework focus group, all four candidates agreed that their course instructors are knowledgeable about content. One candidate celebrated their instructor's prior experience as an instructional facilitator in a nearby school and highlighted the wealth of knowledge and connections she brought from that role to help provide students with more real-life context (such as leveraging those connections to bring in other educational professionals as guest speakers).

Throughout course observations, course instructors showed deep knowledge of the material. For example, in the Secondary Pedagogy course, the instructor spoke knowledgably about the K-12 Standards that candidates were reviewing. When one group was struggling to write questions regarding the American Revolution, the instructor named multiple factors that led to America's independence from Great Britain and offered several examples of ways candidates could write their questions. In another course, the instructor talked about her training with MathQuest and gave very specific feedback about the Standards of Mathematical practice. The course instructor also attended HQIM training in the last few weeks and was also a math teacher and facilitator for multiple years.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors

MEETS

Data shows that all faculty have an average teaching score of 3.0 or higher (out of 5.0), and half of them are above 4.0. During 2024 evaluations, Instructor 1 and Instructor 2 both received strong scores, with average ratings of 4.68 and 4.63, respectively, indicating they are highly effective in their teaching. Both instructors excelled in most areas, particularly in communication, engagement, and professionalism, which contributed to their high ratings. However, there were slight differences. The lower scores in areas like feedback and support (3.58 for Instructor 1 and 3.44 for Instructor 2) suggest there may be room for improvement, particularly in providing timely and personalized feedback or in offering additional support. Despite this, both instructors are considered "very good to excellent" in their roles, demonstrating strong teaching effectiveness.

During the coursework focus group, all four students agreed that their instructors are strong facilitators, that they receive quality feedback from them, and that they have the ongoing support needed to be successful. Candidates named multiple highly effective instructional strategies like stations and jigsaws that are used in their classes. Candidates also described how helpful it is to receive feedback from their professors on lesson plans they create before teaching as part of their field work. Candidates celebrated instructors for utilizing check-ins at the beginning of classes to identify opportunities for support, staying in contact with graduates as they transition to the classroom full time, and providing flexibility for non-traditional candidates who have kids and commute.

During the Education Capstone course, the instructor led students through an expert/home group jigsaw activity in which she facilitated discussion and responded to students' contributions with additional context. The class structure served as an excellent model of what effective teaching looks like, offering a clear example of best practices in the classroom. Additionally, the instructor incorporated high-quality resources, pulling articles from ASCD and Education Week, both of which are well-regarded in the field of education. The instructor also utilized a countdown attention getter to bring the class back together after small-group discussions while minimizing loss of instructional time. In another course, Elementary Frameworks 2, the instructor utilized several strategies for effective facilitation of candidate discussion and small group work, including utilizing countdown attention-getters to bring the whole class back together and having each group share out to their peers. These strategies are utilized in a way that effectively models how candidates could use them in their own classroom. The instructor gave lots of praise in response to students' contributions. For example, when one candidate stated, "he struggles to remember to raise his hand during class discussions", the instructor asked the group to pause so that she could explicitly highlight this statement as an example of the highest professionalism in discussing students. The instructor also utilized several classroom management techniques like the Teach Like a Champion strategy "don't talk over" and the Assertive Discipline strategy "behavior narration". Overall, despite high faculty turnover, the program has been able to maintain a strong program for course instructors and students.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

MEETS

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

MEETS

The overall sequence of clinical experiences clearly builds off previous experiences and includes opportunities for learning and development. Each program has a progression of coursework that is evident through the "Course Progression PPT". It shows clear gradual release for each program showing a sequence of Seminar in education and learning theories courses at the beginning of each program and gradual release to their internship, seminar, and capstone experience. Programs show a progression of learning opportunities with Frameworks I & II and learning opportunities along the way.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group indicated they have a structured progression that begins in the freshman fall semester with 10 hours of classroom observation. As candidates advance, their responsibilities increase, starting with a 10-minute mini-lesson, progressing to weekly lessons tailored to specific content and grade levels, and gradually incorporating more classroom time. This culminates in full day teaching experience, preparing candidates for their senior fall internship. Additionally, candidates participate in targeted rotations for specific content courses, such as math structures, to observe expert modeling, further enriching their pedagogical development and ensuring readiness for independent teaching.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences

MEETS

The clinical experience program is structured to provide candidates with opportunities to support students with varied learning needs across a range of educational settings. The "Field Experience Fall 24" document outlines a strategic variety of placements across grade levels for both pre-internship and internship phases, tailored to course-specific requirements. For instance, reading block courses include targeted K-2 placements to ensure relevant practice opportunities. Additionally, the "Memorandum of Understanding" with school districts guarantees structured internship placements, including one in grades K-3 and one in grades 4-6 for elementary candidates, and one in grades 7-9 and one in grades 7-12 for secondary candidates.

Candidates in the Clinical Experience focus group reinforced the multiple opportunities they have to work with a variety of students. Candidates participate in targeted courses with dedicated clinical hours, such as the Special Education (SPED) course, where they directly support students with special needs. Additionally, they have a requirement of 15 hours working with a certified ESL teacher or observing groups of English language learners to ensure exposure to linguistically diverse populations.

Clinical Supervisors said, "Candidates can benefit from placements across a range of school districts, with the flexibility to request specific placements or continue working with familiar mentor teachers during their internship." They shared that the program accommodates both private and public-school settings, enriching candidates' exposure to different educational environments. During reading blocks, targeted placements enhance candidates' reading instruction skills. Nearly all placements include students with 504 plans, IEPs, or ELL designations, ensuring candidates gain meaningful experience supporting a diverse population and fostering their ability to address a wide spectrum of learning needs.

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

APPROACHING

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers

APPROACHING

Some experienced mentor teachers demonstrate that they have the coaching skills to properly support and develop a candidate's pedagogical development. Documentation outlined the expectations that mentor teachers conduct weekly progress checks utilizing ATR components, teacher candidate reflections, and informal feedback. Experienced mentor teachers are trained in ATR and may have master or lead designation. However, reviewers did not observe evidence for experienced mentor teachers regarding coaching training or coaching experience, evaluation of them as effective mentors, or current/previous data on mentor teacher status as a master/lead teacher.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group unanimously felt they had adequate support from their experienced mentor teacher. They also indicated that they were comfortable asking for help in specific areas. One of the most beneficial supports were the conversations after they taught a lesson. One participant talked about the weekly reflection journal saying, "it was almost infuriating how much we circled back about our weekly reflections, but it kept us accountable."

Participants in the School Partnership focus group unanimously agreed that their school has a designated coaching model but were unaware of JBU's coaching model/protocols and were unaware if the mentor teacher provides coaching to their teacher candidate. The mentor teacher reviewers spoke with did not discuss any training from the EPP prior to starting as a mentor teacher. Clinical supervisors shared similar feedback and could not speak to mentor teacher's abilities or frequency of feedback or coaching, though they all agreed teacher candidates are adequately supported by their experienced mentors.

Note: By 2026-2027, experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents must have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. *Arkansas Novice Teacher Mentoring Manual*

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers

MEETS

A clear process is in place to select experienced mentor teachers. The "District MOU Addendum" provided by the EPP indicates that experienced mentor teachers must have at least three years of classroom experience, a rating of effective or highly effective on evaluation, and recommendation of building principal.

Participants in the Partnership focus group unanimously agreed that they utilize experienced classroom teachers who have effective or highly effective reviews and are "overall well-rounded teachers."

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

APPROACHING

Some clinical supervisors show evidence of effective instructional practices. Three of the five program clinical supervisors show evidence of training for the Aspiring Teaching Rubric. Only one faculty member is listed as having training in coaching, but the coaching model is not mentioned or when that training was received.

While reviewers saw evidence of strong coaching in some observations, the review team noted that coaching observations did not seem to follow a specific protocol across all observations. Only one of the observations followed the ATR and discussed growth, progress and areas to improve. The other coaching sessions were more focused on guided reflection and encouragement. In one observation, reviewers noted the supervisor emphasized the importance of addressing a student's derogatory behavior toward another, underscoring the need to foster a positive classroom environment and climate. Through probing questions, such as "What happens next after looking at what they wrote?", the supervisor pushed the candidate's thinking about the struggle with transitioning knowledge between activities, prompting reflection on her planning. However, while the supervisor included guiding questions to encourage reflection, they did not provide specific, bite-sized, and actionable next steps. The clinical supervisor could have offered more concrete, targeted questions and strategies to help the candidate improve in identified areas of the lesson. None of the coaching observations referenced the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, though evidence of the ATR was seen in written post-observation feedback.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates

MEETS

Candidates consistently receive high-quality feedback from their clinical supervisor and mentor teacher. Evidence shows that candidate feedback is documented weekly and aligned to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. Candidate's feedback and progress are tracked within one document which allows teacher candidates to self-monitor and mentor teachers and EPP faculty to ensure the candidate is successful. The feedback from the mentor teacher and from the EPP faculty is structured to build on positive growth from previous feedback as well as provide meaningful areas for development.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group indicated that they received quality feedback from their clinical supervisor, especially through the POP cycles. All participants agreed they found great value in the encouragement they received from their clinical supervisor. They all indicated that they could reach out to their clinical supervisor at any time and they were always available to help them when needed, even if it was something simple such as just checking in on them. Participants also discussed the feedback they receive from their experienced mentor teacher. All participants indicated they received weekly written feedback as well as informal feedback after the lesson i.e. sticky notes and general conversations from their mentor teachers. Most of the focus group was able to participate in their placement school PLC group and found that experience to be valuable in looking at data and determining student needs. One member of the focus group who did not have that experience indicated that opportunity would have been beneficial.

Clinical Supervisors all agreed that they utilize the rubric aligned to TESS and completed weekly by the teacher candidate and experienced mentor teacher to ensure a successful clinical internship for teacher candidates. Candidates also complete a data focused assignment which includes a rubric, reflection, and feedback.

In one observation, reviewers noted multiple examples of the clinical supervisor demonstrating specific coaching skills to support candidates. During the coaching video, the supervisor provides specific examples that are tied to timestamps on the observation video. For example, she uses timestamps to show candidates the areas she wants to discuss, such as the times when she has her back turned to the class and uses the analogy of working with a basketball team to help her understand the concept of "with-it-ness." She also asks probing questions like, "Did you actually complete the activity before you taught it?" which allowed the candidate to think through her actions. The supervisor uses specific evidence and shows the correlation with the Arkansas Educator Competencies for elementary education.

In another observation, reviewers noted the clinical supervisor utilized guiding questions to both show growth of the teacher candidate as well as areas for improvement, asking "Did the students learn what you intended? Do you believe your instructional goals were met? How do you know?" The Clinical supervisor referred back to previous goals to allow for self-reflection, "What are two areas that you have seen yourself grow? What would be your focus goals for the future?"

Note: The Aspiring Teacher Rubric must be in use by EPPs by the 2024-25 academic year.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

APPROACHING

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools

APPROACHING

Collaborative processes are in place with some districts/schools to co-construct the clinical internship for candidates. The EPP has created MOUs for their partnership outlining the expectations for the school and university. Additionally, the "Internship PowerPoint" presented at the Cooperating Teachers' meeting details expectations for candidates; however, it does not go into full detail with mentor expectations as outlined in the handbook. Furthermore, evidence of a Professional Development School (PDS) meeting with district partners demonstrates ongoing collaboration, reinforcing the cooperative approach for clinical internships that support candidate development.

Participants in the Partnership focus group shared that communication primarily occurs informally via email with the option to request meetings as needed. One principal noted regular interactions with the EPP, including frequent school visits to monitor candidate progress and ensure alignment. However, experienced mentor training lacks consistency, with most participants reporting no formal orientation. Experienced mentors often rely on candidates to clarify assignment expectations. While one participant recalled an EPP meeting with mentor teachers, it is unclear if this is standard practice. Mentor teachers receive surveys to provide feedback on their experiences and feel comfortable contacting the EPP directly when necessary, indicating an open channel for input, though more structured collaboration and training could enhance the process.

The experienced mentor teacher affirmed this information, saying, "Clarity of expectations would be something I'd like more of – I'd like to know what my candidate is getting feedback on."

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors

MEETS

The EPP submitted two slides that show the Teacher Education Department meets regularly to discuss programmatic updates. In the "Teacher Education Department Meeting October 29" deck, the team discussed the requirement for all faculty to be trained on the ATR, discussed changes to the disposition form and handbook, and discussed incorporating HQIM into the capstone course.

Participants in the Clinical Supervisor focus group agreed that they felt supported in their professional development needs. Participants indicated that they meet as a department and have a faculty retreat in early fall to discuss needs and map out the upcoming year. Participants did not indicate any unmet needs or lack of support.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework

MEETS

Based on data reviewed, most candidates show proficiency in meeting coursework requirements. For example, in looking at the "Grades for Spring 2024-2025," evidence shows that of the six programs provided, the average GPA was a 3.46 or better. Of the 100 students, 89% are at a 3.00 or higher.

Based on the "Fall 2024 Low Grade Report," only two students out of 79 (3%) earned a grade below a "C". Data submitted for Spring 2025, showed that most students meet proficiency in their courses.

Page 14 of the handbook indicated that candidates must have a 2.7 GPA or higher (as well as a "C" or better in all major courses). There were approximately 11% of students who did not meet those requirements. The Advising notes indicate that all students have an education advisor who keeps track of grades and concerns. The university also activates a campus-wide alert system if a student is falling below expectations

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework

MEETS

Candidates are consistently provided with an individualized support plan if their coursework requirements are not on track. The EPP has set up systems of support both in individual coursework (ED 4272) and program-wide (Concern Form, Transition Plans). Coursework instructors have indicated that they are open to helping students redo work if needed. Across the program, there are transitions where students take an active role in providing evidence of their preparation. If there are concerns, advisors and faculty can fill out a concern form that provides an individualized plan of support. Both systems provide ways for students to take an active role in their support. Through all three transitions, a plan exists for candidates to have a progress check and recommended follow-up as needed. For example, data provided shows that two students were noted as needing follow-up after Transition 1, and then were shown to be successful in both Transition 2 and 3. This indicates that the system is providing support that is effective in getting students back on track.

Course instructors in the focus group confirmed a process exists for support plans in coursework. Faculty and advisors know their students and advisees well, allowing them to quickly notice signs of academic difficulty, such as missed classes or poor performance. While there isn't a formal tracking tool, concerns are addressed through departmental discussions, and students are often enrolled in multiple classes with the same instructors, enabling consistent monitoring. Tools like anecdotal records and a university-wide support team are also available. The Ally Alert system helps flag freshmen who may need additional support, and a university-wide support team is also available. When a student is identified as being at risk, their advisor meets with them to create an informal individualized support plan, with multiple follow-ups to track progress. Students are given more than one opportunity to succeed, and faculty maintain open-door policies, offering an environment where students feel seen, supported, and encouraged to take an active role in their academic journey.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones

MEETS

Programs have a set of clear and appropriate goals and milestones for clinical internships. Most candidates meet clinical experience goals and milestones. The EPP provided a mentor teacher document, the "Weekly Progress Report" that mentors and candidates complete each week. Evidence showed distinct check in dates, but the milestones/goals were not listed. While documentation could better outline program goals and milestones, participants in the Clinical Experience focus group all agreed that they understood program goals and objectives. They also understood the process used to monitor their progress using the EPP rubric along with their mentor teacher and clinical faculty. Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group agreed that their students are all successful within the internship. Teacher candidates are aware of their internship and self-identified goals and provide weekly feedback along with their mentor teacher to monitor and reflect on their goals.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

APPROACHING

There is some evidence to suggest candidates can impact student growth. Documentation provided states that student growth is discussed in POP cycle conversations. Candidates complete a Capstone project that requires them to gather and analyze data to determine if their students are learning.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group agreed that they felt confident in measuring student growth. The candidates who were able to participate in a school PLC indicated it was a valuable experience in analyzing student data and refining their teaching. Not all candidates receive that support due to their school placement. Reviewers did not observe evidence involving the utilization of informal assessment, such as exit tickets or regrouping students based on data trends.

Clinical Supervisors shared that candidates have an assignment requiring pre and post data to analyze and work with students. Candidates use the mentor teacher's beginning of the year data for this assignment and track students across the semester. Clinical supervisors follow up after teaching lessons and ask candidates if the students learned the content and how they know. They discuss the use of formative assessments with students and the interventions cycles and data to show student growth.

Reviewers noted some informal evidence of candidate's impact on student growth in coaching observations. Reviewers did not observe any formal assessments in the coaching videos provided. However, in four of the five coaching sessions, informal questions were asked to probe candidates about their student growth. For example, one

clinical supervisor asked "Did the students learn what you intended? Do you believe your instructional goals were met? How do you know?" The candidate's response did not involve formal or informal assessment, but rather her observation whether students raised their hand to answer. While the candidate can observe and reflect, there is no clear evidence submitted that they have analyzed data to inform future instructional strategies effectively.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

At the end of their clinical internship, most candidates receive a score of 'effective' or demonstrate strong growth towards an 'effective' rating on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. For example, many students who interned in spring 2024 and completed in December 2024, were consistently earning effective ratings in most Aspiring TESS components. Most of the domains were rated at least 80% Effective, with 2C, 2E, and 4F having 100% of interns effective.

To support candidates reaching effectiveness, POP cycle forms containing questions requiring specific examples from their classroom and teaching were provided as evidence.

Note: By 2024-25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

MEETS

All candidates with varied needs are provided with the support they need and are consistently provided with an individualized support plan if their development in the clinical internship is not on track. A full example of one candidate's formal observation and post-conference was reviewed in the documentation. The candidate had several strengths, such as rapport with students, communication, and organization. Areas of growth included getting the attention of the class before giving instructions and thinking through lessons and possible student responses before teaching. Evidence was provided of pre- and post-observation conferences, as well as the documentation to support them.

Participants in the Clinical Experience focus group indicated they knew support plans existed for struggling candidates but did not have direct experience with them. All focus group participants felt supported by their clinical supervisor and mentor teacher. They felt they received adequate feedback and appreciated the openness of being able to ask for feedback on specific areas i.e. pacing, grouping, engagement. They all agreed that they found value in their experienced mentor teacher and clinical supervisor's ability to "normalize failure" and how to reflect and grow from the lessons that were not the best.

Clinical Supervisors affirmed these findings. Focus group participants agreed that they were aware and informed of the protocol for support plans and agreed that their students do not utilize these support plans often. High achieving teacher candidates have been provided opportunities to participate in national and state conferences as well as acknowledgement from their peers in the form of The Outstanding Senior Award.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

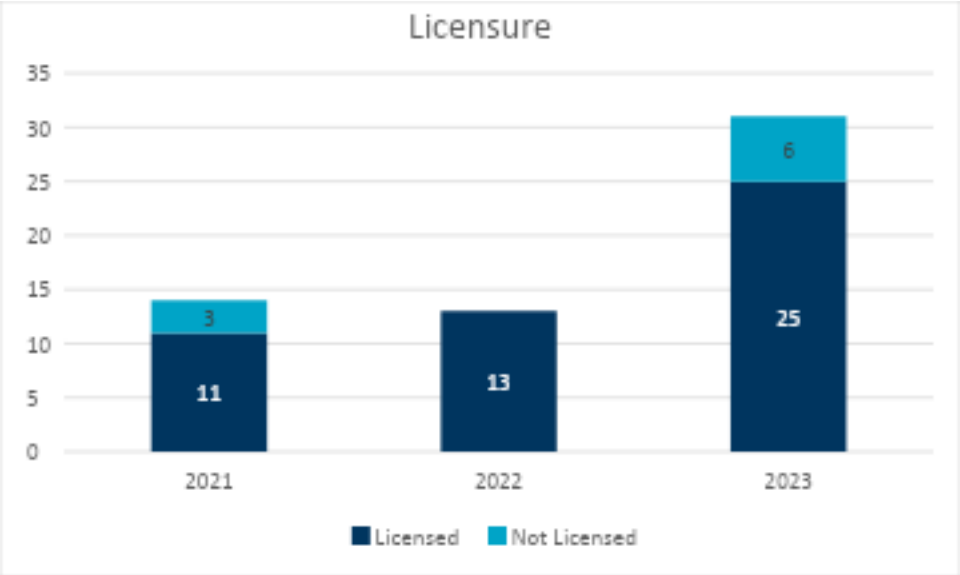
Standard 3 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	**Indicator 3.2 Employment**	**Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness**
EXCEEDS	BELOW	MEETS
Recommendations		

Recommendations include:

- Although a high proportion of program completers earn standard Arkansas licensure, a low proportion of completers are working in Arkansas public schools. Pursue initiatives to encourage candidates to consider employment in Arkansas public schools once licensed. *(Focus Area: Indicator 3.2)*
- Continue to review EPP Completer Supervisor Survey and EPP Completer Survey results to identify specific domains and components for which both supervisors and candidates do not feel their program prepared them well to become a teacher. *(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3a and 3.3b)*

INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	**Target**	**EPP's Percentage Licensed**	**Performance Level**
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license within one year of completion.	80%	84%	EXCEEDS

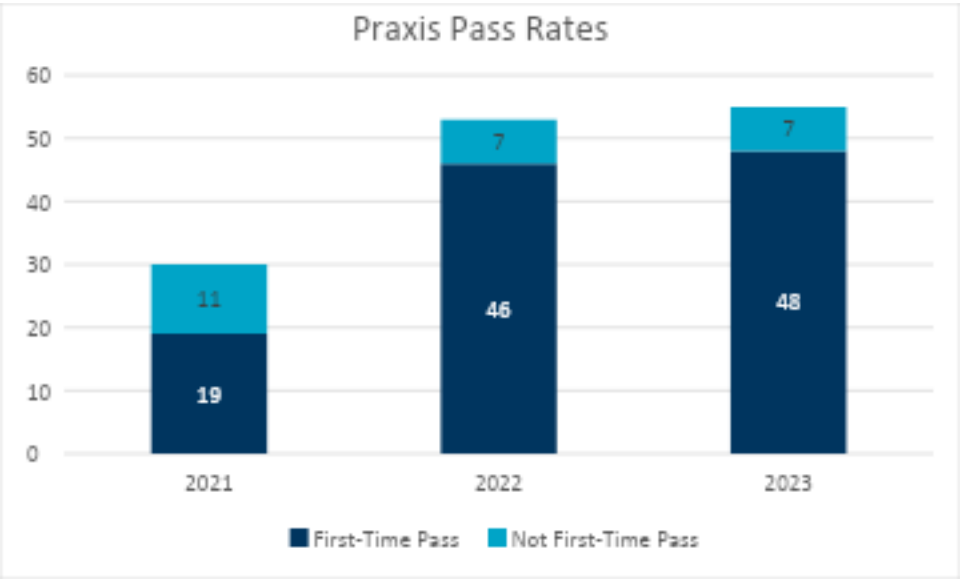


Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	73%	n/a	n/a

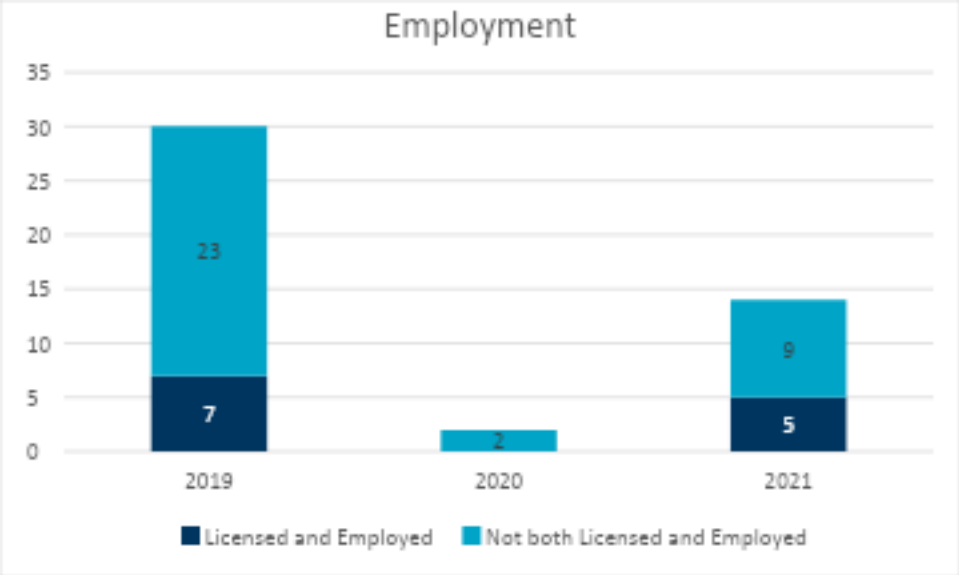
Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	66%	81.9%	EXCEEDS

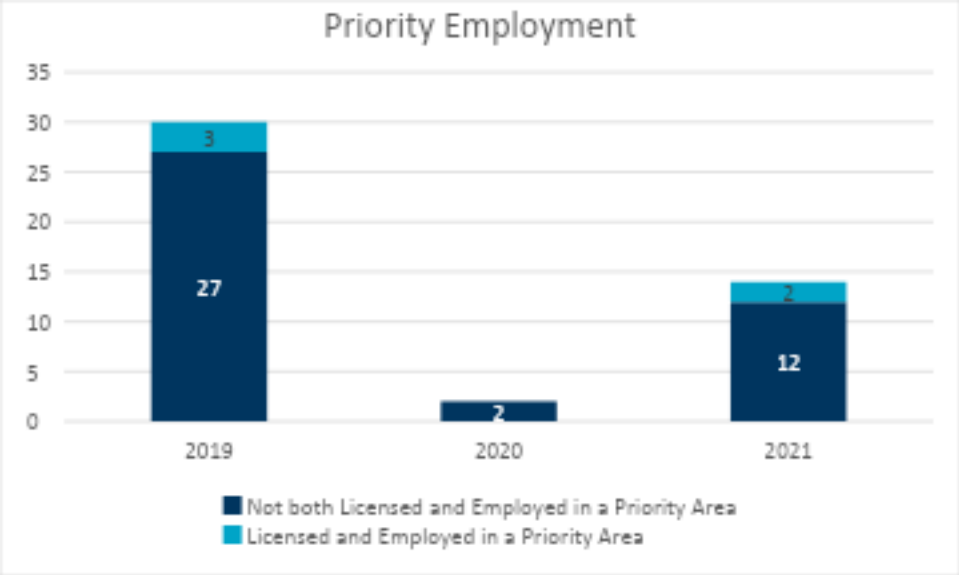

Praxis Pass Rates
60
50
40
30
20
10
0
11
19
7
46
7
48
2021
2022
2023
First-Time Pass
Not First-Time Pass

INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools			
Metric	**Target**	**EPP's Percentage Employed**	**Performance Level**
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	68%	26.1%	BELOW



Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects			
Metric	**Target**	**EPP's Percentage Employed Priority**	**Performance Level**
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	39%	10.9%	BELOW



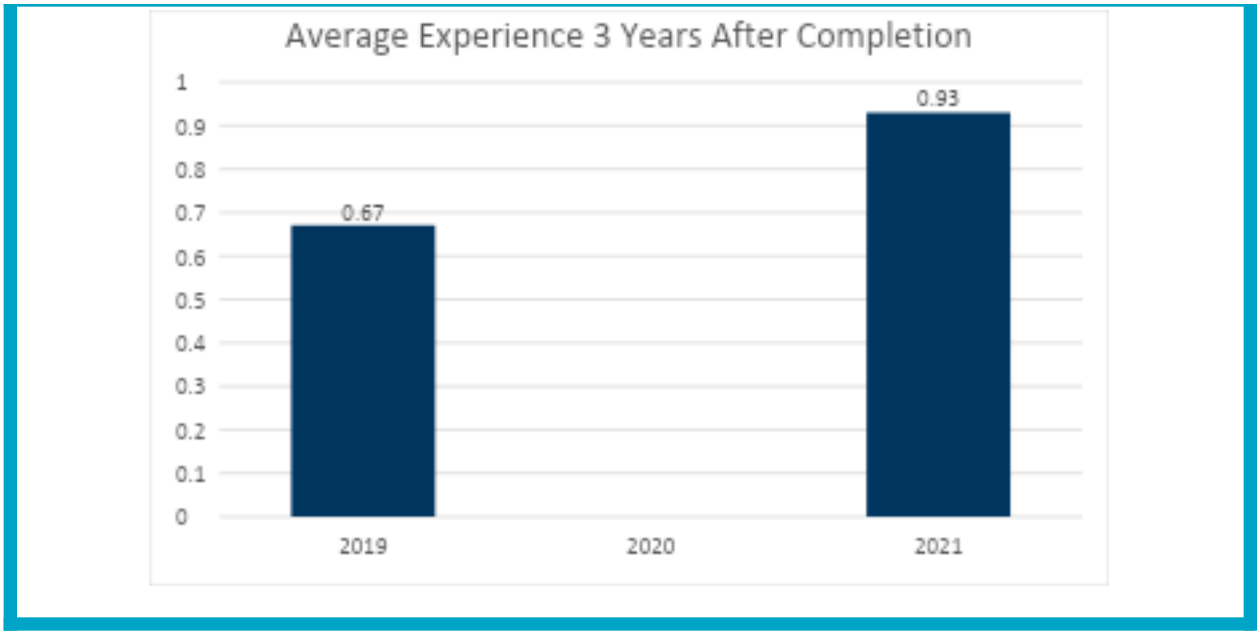
*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas.

Current subject shortage areas for employment: Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

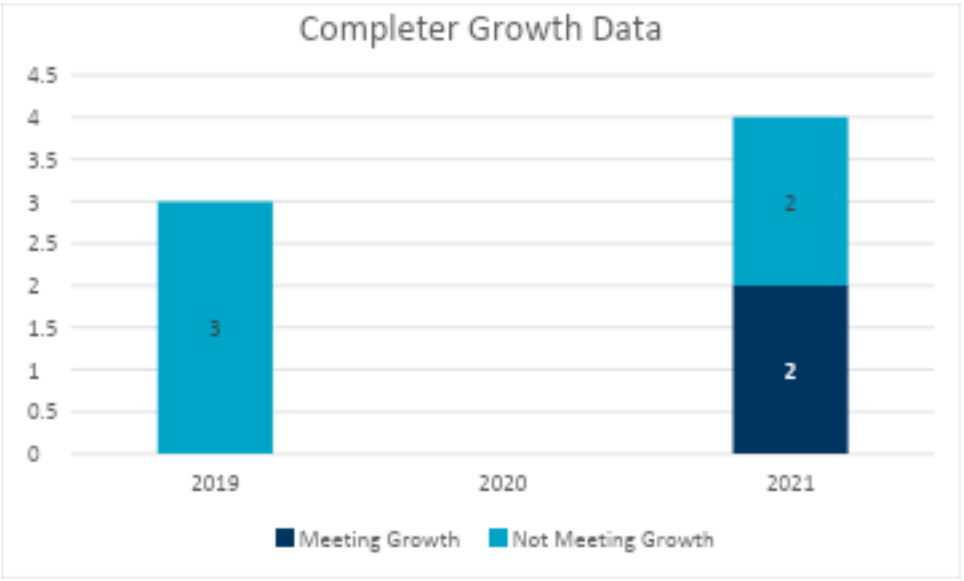
Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.8	.72	BELOW


Average Experience 3 Years After Completion
1
0.9
0.8
0.7
0.6
0.5
0.4
0.3
0.2
0.1
0
0.67
0.93
2019
2020
2021

INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	78%	81.8%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	79%	83.3%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	29%	BELOW


Completer Growth Data
4.5
4
3.5
3
2.5
2
1.5
1
0.5
0
3
2
2
2019
2020
2021
Meeting Growth
Not Meeting Growth